

Foreword

It is my pleasure to introduce you to this book of baby play. Having worked with children and families for nearly 30 years, and as a mother myself, I know how invaluable this accessible resource of practical play ideas will be to help you keep your baby entertained and learning through this wonderful first year. Play can be as simple or complex as suits you and your baby, and the themes and ideas in this book will support you whatever your preference.

I have loved every minute of working on the ideas you'll find in the coming pages. I've drawn on my experience of keeping my own three boys busy and learning, and on my knowledge and experience in child development, which informs each idea and tip.

Within each chapter you'll find activities that benefit your baby in the realms of speech and language, fine and gross motor skills, building relationships, and encouraging thinking and problem solving. It's great to know that play promotes development, but as you try out the ideas in this book, bear in mind that enjoyment, fun, and closeness are key to successful playtime.

We've focused mainly on activities that are simple to create or set up and rely on many everyday items. We also recognize that a stimulating home environment is a perfect place in which your baby can play, as is your own yard or nearest green space. Whether you have one baby, twins, or more, you'll find play ideas here to suit the situation with the minimum set-up time and maximum play value—something that's important when you are juggling the tasks of being a parent.

My favorite idea, one developed when my children were young and we had limited outdoor play space, is the suitcase sandbox (page 204). It was such a nice surprise for my children when we opened up the suitcase to reveal a sandbox with a few toys scattered on top. We got plenty of use from that suitcase—with some mess, of course—and I have lasting memories of the fun we had.

Of course, being a parent isn't all fun and games. No parent is immune to feeling bored sometimes, perhaps exhausted as sleepless nights or an unsettled baby take their toll, or simply at a loss about how to keep an eager baby entertained. That's why, in the pages to come, you'll find an array of fresh ideas, or a twist on something you may have already tried. Our goal is to lift the pressure on you to think up a completely new activity every time. Dip into these pages and let these suggestions do some of the work for you. I hope you find this book inspiring and valuable, and that you and your baby enjoy this precious year together.

